



angry young man to the nibbling doubts of old age, from nationalism to an easy globalism, from physical violence to the new techniques of an information society. The mellower Bachchan is teaching India, especially the older Indians, to enjoy themselves. He reminds you in *Baghban* that the mind and heart do not retire at 58; as sexy Sam, he shows that sex is not a duty you wrap up at 20 but a domain of continuous enjoyment. His is the unity of a life cycle breaking standard stereotypes, reminding one that unity, to be true to life, must be larger than life and also life-giving.

While Bachchan and the mellower Amitji covered the larger canvas, the bevy of Khans—Amir, Shah Rukh and Salman and the likes of Ajay Devgan and Sanjay Dutt—provided their own form of cultural problem-solving. As genres go, there is first the gangster-cop movie centering around violence and excessive corruption. Movies like *Company* and *Ganga Jal* demonstrate the need for a new sense of legality, of the Constitution providing a new framework for India. It also shows that if anything can corrode India, it is violence, not just terror but all the kaleidoscopic variations from incest and rape to torture and displacement. Violence, as the philosopher Hannah Arendt observed, is the end of politics as problem-solving. While playing out the seductive aesthetics of violence, Bollywood does convey its limits as an ethics or a philosophy. Yet it also hints that our mode of repression is such that what we can't find in sex, we seek in violence, the orgasmic release that promises to liberate or pretends to.

Yet oddly and wonderfully, Bollywood also produces a movie like *Veer Zaara* which argues that for true unity, the arid nationalism of *Border* will not do. *Veer Zaara* anticipates a peace, a conversation, a friendship that our middle class hawks do not understand. It shows how important the problem of memory is to the problematic unity. Memory is site, scar, invention, and lived memory embodies a different world from ersatz memory. Lived memory is complex and nuanced. It has a mnemonic of mixed feelings which ersatz or borrowed memory cannot claim. Whether it is Gandhi, Bhagat Singh or Pakistan, one has to live through history as storytelling for unity to survive. Myth without history dissipates itself and history without myth is impotent. That much *Rang De Basanti*, *Lagaan* and *Gandhi, My Father* showed. An authentic encounter with history can redeem culture by reworking demonologies. The British and the Pakistanis become intimate enemies rather than monsters, and that Bollywood shows brilliantly.

However, mirrors of the past also need lenses

THE STARS:
Nargis, Kapoor
and Kumar



The trinity of Raj Kapoor, Dilip Kumar and Dev Anand represented a unity no other *trishul* could match. *Mera joota hai Japanese* was as powerful an anthem as *Jana Gana Mana*.

for the future. The future is our double in time and in an everyday sense, the diaspora is our double. We play Americans as in *Kal Ho Na Ho*; we display their easy masculinity; the encounter between men and women is not a set of semaphores but a conversation. In a strange absorptive way, the American Dream gets indigenised as a new variant of desire. There is also a humour to this. In *Kaante*, a few Indians, while celebrating the diasporic dream, feel it is woefully incomplete. One of them complains that while the Italians have their Mafia, the Chinese their Tongs, the Japanese their Yakuza, Indians can parade no ethnicity of crime. It is a profound statement that unity and identity are not unidimensional, that unity always needs its silliness and its shadows. Bollywood is a cultural psychotherapy without which the Indian dream becomes sadly empty or horribly secular. Bollywood provides both the shadows and a sense of magic to the Indian sense of unity as a conversation and a prayer rather than a tyranny of uniforms and uniformity.



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